Chapter 2

Anthem
Leonard Cohen



Before proceeding to read further, please listen to the song “Anthem” by Leonard Cohen by scanning the QR code provided

Learning Outcome

By the end of this chapter, you will understand Leonard Cohen’s artistic background and analyse the central themes of his song *“Anthem.”* They will interpret key ideas such as resilience, institutional failure, and the acceptance of imperfection, supported by certain excerpts of the song. You will evaluate the song’s philosophical, spiritual, and cultural significance.

Introduction

Leonard Cohen was a celebrated Canadian singer-songwriter, poet, and novelist whose artistic career spanned over six decades. Born in 1934 in Westmount, Quebec, Canada, Cohen began as a poet and novelist, publishing early notable works such as *Let Us Compare Mythologies* (1956), *The Spice-Box of Earth* (1961), and the novels *The Favourite Game* (1963) and *Beautiful Losers* (1966). His transition to music in the late 1960s brought him international recognition, with songs like “Suzanne,” “So Long, Marianne,” and “Bird on the Wire.” Cohen’s music is known for its deep philosophical reflections, spir itual questioning, and unique blend of folk, pop, and liturgical influences. His works often explore themes of love, loss, longing, faith, political conflict, and the human struggle for meaning. The blend of biblical imagery and emotional honesty in his lyrics contributed to his reputation as a profound and introspective artist. Throughout his life, Cohen remained committed to exploring the tensions between the sacred and the secular, the personal and the political, and despair and hope. His contributions to literature and music earned him a lasting place among the most influential cultural figures of the twentieth century.

Leonard Cohen’s song “Anthem,” released in 1992 on the album *The Future*, is one of his most widely admired works, celebrated for its powerful message of hope amid imperfection. The song is built around the iconic refrain, “There is a crack in everything, that’s how the light gets in,” expressing the idea that human flaws and societal failures are not obstacles to redemption, but openings through which change and enlightenment can occur. Its themes revolve around forgiveness, resilience, spiritual awakening, and accepting the brokenness of the world while striving for light and renewal. Cohen reflects on political turmoil, personal struggle, and global uncertainty, suggesting that meaning can still emerge from chaos. Public reception of “Anthem” has been overwhelmingly positive, with the song becoming an enduring cultural touchstone. It has been quoted in political speeches, adopted in peace movements, and embraced by listeners seeking comfort during crises. Over time, “Anthem” has grown in relevance, often resurfacing during moments of collective hardship. Its blend of poetic wisdom and emotional resonance has made it

one of Cohen’s most cherished songs, reminding audiences that hope persists even in the most fractured moments of life.

Lyrics

The birds they sang
At the break of day
Start again
I heard them say
Don't dwell on what
Has passed away
Or what is yet to be

Yeah the wars they will
Be fought again
The holy dove
She will be caught again
Bought and sold
And bought again
The dove is never free

Ring the bells that still can ring
Forget your perfect offering
There is a crack, a crack in everything
That's how the light gets in

We asked for signs
The signs were sent:
The birth betrayed
The marriage spent
Yeah the widowhood
Of every government
Signs for all to see

I can't run no more
With that lawless crowd
While the killers in high places
Say their prayers out loud
But they've summoned, they've summoned up
A thundercloud
And they're going to hear from me

Ring the bells that still ring
Forget your perfect offering
There is a crack, a crack in everything
That's how the light gets in

You can add up the parts
You won't have the sum
You can strike up the march

There is no drum
Every heart, every heart
To love will come
But like a refugee

Ring the bells that still can ring
Forget your perfect offering
There is a crack, a crack in everything
That's how the light gets in

Ring the bells that still can ring
Forget your perfect offering
There is a crack, a crack in everything
That's how the light gets in
That's how the light gets in
That's how the light gets in

Summary and Interpretation

Perpetual Conflict and Failed Governance

The opening stanzas of "Anthem" immediately establish a cyclical, often discouraging, world view, which is essential context for the song's eventual message of resilience. The speaker notes the constant necessity for renewal, referencing the birds singing at daybreak and urging one to "Start again I heard them say / Don't dwell on what / Has passed away / Or what is yet to be". This suggests a timeless pattern where hope must be actively renewed, rather than passively received.

This call for resilience is countered by the grim reality of perpetual societal conflict. Cohen identifies the enduring nature of human conflict ("the wars they will / Be fought again") and the loss of innocence or peace, symbolised by the "holy dove" which "will be caught again / Bought and sold / And bought again / The dove is never free". This imagery interprets peace and innocence not as fixed ideals, but as commodities continually betrayed and exploited.

Furthermore, the song critically assesses political and institutional failure, noting that society was given "signs" which manifested as betrayal: "The birth betrayed / The marriage spent / Yeah the widowhood / Of every government / Signs for all to see". These elements collectively paint a picture of political systems that have failed their purpose, leading to pervasive disillusionment.

Resistance and Accountability

The middle section shifts the focus to the speaker's personal response to this societal decay. The speaker distances himself from hypocrisy and corruption, declaring, "I can't run no more / With that lawless crowd / While the killers in high places / Say their prayers out loud". This signifies a rejection of silent complicity and a commitment to moral resistance against those who maintain power while practicing hypocrisy.

The passage introduces an element of impending retribution, as the powerful have "summoned, they've summoned up / A thundercloud / And they're going to hear from me". This moment acts as a pivot, transforming disillusionment into determination, indicating that the speaker intends to challenge the established, corrupt order.

The Core Thesis: Light Through the Crack

The central and most critical interpretation of the song resides in its repeated refrain, which serves as the anthem's central thesis:

"Ring the bells that still can ring / Forget your perfect offering / There is a crack, a crack in everything / That's how the light gets in".

This passage offers a profound spiritual and philosophical directive. The instruction here is to "Forget your perfect offering". This suggests that true spiritual or emotional progress is blocked by the impossible pursuit of faultless perfection. Instead, one must accept the inherent imperfections—the "crack, a crack in everything"—whether in oneself, institutions, or relationships. It is through

these very flaws and vulnerabilities that "light gets in," suggesting that revelation, grace, or genuine understanding can only enter through existing brokenness.

Complexity and the Vulnerability of Love

Cohen reinforces the idea that life and truth defy simple quantification. He notes the complexity of the human condition cannot be grasped through mere arithmetic: "You can add up the parts / You won't have the sum". This suggests that the whole is greater (or fundamentally different) than the elements measured.

This theme of necessary vulnerability is further applied to human connection. Love, the song concludes, is inevitable ("Every heart, every heart / To love will come"), but its arrival is characterised by fragility: "But like a refugee". This interprets love not as a triumphant, guaranteed ideal, but as a vulnerable, exiled state, accessible only when one is willing to accept the brokenness implied by the refugee metaphor.

In summary, "Anthem" teaches the essential lesson that efficient personal and spiritual growth does not require flawless offerings, but rather the courageous acceptance of imperfection, which allows necessary insight and renewal to enter the broken world.

Major Themes

Imperfection as the Pathway to Grace

This is arguably the most recognised and essential theme, efficiently conveyed through the repeated refrain. It provides a philosophical instruction for efficient living and spiritual access:

- **Accepting Flaws:** The song encourages the listener to "Forget your perfect offering". This suggests that the pursuit of flawlessness is a barrier to genuine spiritual experience.
- **The Necessity of Brokenness:** Grace or revelation ("the light") is accessed not despite imperfections, but *through* them. The core message states: "There is a crack, a crack in everything / That's how the light gets in". This metaphor proposes that flaws are necessary channels for truth or salvation.
- **Action Over Aspiration:** The related instruction to "Ring the bells that still can ring" suggests utilising what remains functional, rather than striving for an unattainable ideal.

Cycles of Conflict and the Need for Renewal

The poem establishes the world as a place where decay and conflict are continuous, necessitating constant effort to "start again". This theme emphasises resilience and a non-attachment to the past or future:

- **Continuous Conflict:** The speaker acknowledges that "the wars they will / Be fought again". This suggests that conflict is a persistent aspect of the human condition, cycling through history.
- **Loss of Innocence:** Closely tied to conflict is the recurring capture and sale of the "holy dove," which "will be caught again / Bought and sold / And bought again". The source states

explicitly that "The dove is never free," interpreting innocence or peace not as a stable state, but as a vulnerable commodity.

- **Call to Start Anew:** Despite the persistence of conflict, the speaker relays the message heard at daybreak: "Start again... Don't dwell on what / Has passed away / Or what is yet to be". This serves as an instruction to focus on the present moment and renew hope continuously.

Institutional Failure and Moral Resistance

The poem presents a strong critique of governments and powerful establishments, pairing this societal failure with the speaker's personal moral stand against corruption:

- **Betrayal by Institutions:** The poem notes that people "asked for signs," and these signs were delivered in the form of deep institutional and social failure: "The birth betrayed / The marriage spent / Yeah the widowhood / Of every government". These failures are presented as readily apparent ("Signs for all to see").
- **Rejection of Hypocrisy:** The speaker explicitly rejects complicity with the corrupt establishment, stating, "I can't run no more / With that lawless crowd". The hypocrisy of the powerful is highlighted by the "killers in high places" who nonetheless "Say their prayers out loud".
- **Accountability:** The poem concludes this section with a promise of consequence, noting that the powerful have "summoned up / A thundercloud" and "they're going to hear from me," signalling a demand for moral accountability.

Complexity and Vulnerability

The final theme reinforces that life's truths are complex and defy simple analysis, particularly when dealing with love:

- **The Vulnerability of Love:** Love is presented as an inevitable human experience—"Every heart, every heart / To love will come". However, its arrival is not triumphant but characterised by fragility, as it comes "But like a refugee". This imagery interprets love as a state of vulnerability or exile.

Check Your Progress

Multiple Choice Questions

1. According to the poem, what instruction is heard at the break of day that encourages renewal and resilience?

A. Focus only on what is yet to be.
B. Start again, and do not dwell on the past or future.
C. Ring the bells that still can ring, ignoring the past.
D. Fight the wars that will be fought again.

2. What specific critique is offered regarding the "holy dove," often symbolising peace or innocence?

A. It is often forgotten when the wars are fought.
B. It sings to announce the need to start again.
C. It is continually caught, bought, and sold, confirming it is "never free".
D. It represents the perfect offering that must be forgotten.

3. The speaker rejects complicity with the "lawless crowd" and highlights the hypocrisy of the powerful by noting that the "killers in high places" are doing what action?

A. Summoning a thundercloud.
B. Running away from the battle.
C. Saying their prayers out loud.
D. Adding up the parts to find the sum.

4. What metaphorical element is identified as the necessary channel for "the light" to enter, reflecting the central theme of grace through imperfection?

A. The ringing of the bells that still can ring.
B. The birth betrayed or the marriage spent.
C. A crack, a crack in everything.
D. The finding of a drum for the march.

5. The poem states that "Every heart, every heart / To love will come." However, how is the arrival of this love characterised, indicating a sense of vulnerability?

A. Like a perfect offering.
B. Like a lawless crowd.
C. Like a thundercloud.
D. But like a refugee.

6. Leonard Cohen's "Anthem" is often interpreted as a call for:

A. Revolution
B. Acceptance of flaws and imperfections
C. Economic reform
D. Political change

7. In "Anthem," Cohen mentions "the bells," which can be interpreted as a metaphor for:

A. War and conflict
B. Joy and celebration
C. Tradition and routine
D. Change and awakening

8. Leonard Cohen's "Anthem" encourages listeners to:

A. Strive for perfection in all things
B. Embrace imperfection as a part of life
C. Ignore the world's problems
D. Seek wealth and success above all else

Correct Answers:

1. B ; 2. C ; 3. C ; 4. C ; 5. D ; 6. B : 7. D ; 8. B

Short Answer Questions

1. How will you define the lines "There is a crack, a crack in everything/That's how the light gets in”?
2. Why was "Anthem" considered as a redemptive hymn?
3. How was "Anthem" received by critics and the public when it was first released?
4. What specific action taken by the "killers in high places" is cited by the speaker as an example of their hypocrisy?
5. What fundamental philosophical instruction must one "forget" in order to allow the light to enter?

Essay Questions

1. What are the central messages conveyed in Leonard Cohen's "Anthem"?
2. How does "Anthem" explore the concept of existentialism, particularly in the context of accepting the flawed nature of humanity and the world?
3. "Anthem" reflects Cohen's exploration of religious and spiritual themes. Discuss with examples.

Activities for Listening

1. Listen to music or songs and write down what you hear. This improves your ability to focus on and retain details.
2. Self-Practice: Read the song aloud to yourself. Pay attention to how your voice changes to convey the emotional difference. By listening to your own inflection, you practice identifying how subtle changes in delivery affect the message being decoded.